HERE SUPPLY CO.

A COURSE FOR MEN WHO CARRY A LOT

Carry It Well.

Nine problems men actually say out loud, and what to do about each one.

The Solo · See it · Carry it · Build it

Write in it. Mark it up. Come back to it when life gets loud.

WHAT IS INSIDE

The Solo and nine lessons in three parts, each one at home and at work,
with two pages to write on after every lesson.
Use the online course for a quick read. Use this book for the work.

START HERE

How the course works.

One lesson a week for nine weeks, in three parts. See it (lessons 1 to 3) is about being honest about where you are. Carry it (4 to 6) is about the load you carry. Build it (7 to 9) is about what lasts after you. Before the first lesson, you take half a day alone with a notebook.

Every lesson starts with something men actually say out loud, then gives you the moment you will recognize, what is really going on, the principle, a practice in four steps, a version for hard weeks, how it plays out at home and at work, an honest alternative if it does not fit your life, why it helps, words to use, what to watch for, and this week's assignment. After each lesson there are two pages for you.

The order

0 **The Solo, this week**
Half a day outside, phone in the truck, three questions on paper.

1 **One lesson a week**
Read it on Sunday. Try the practice all week, at home and at work.

2 **Print the sheet**
Each lesson has one, printed from its lesson page. Put it where the moment happens.

3 **Write here what actually happened**
Not what should have happened. Answer the question I would ask you on a call.

4 **Keep the two that helped**
The last page. Let the rest wait without guilt.

Nine lessons

1 **The Honest Map**
"I don't know what I want anymore."

2 **The Drift**
"I'm on my phone or a drink every night and I don't like it."

3 **Short Fuse**
"I snap at the people I love most."

4 **Choose Your Battles**
"Everything is on me."

5 **Enough**
"Work owns me."

6 **Fuel**
"I'm running on fumes."

7 **Your Council**
"I don't have one friend I could call at 2 AM."

8 **The Inheritance**
"I'm turning into my dad."

9 **What You Pass On**
"My kids are growing up and I'm missing it."

BEFORE YOU START · HALF A DAY

The Solo

> **Half a day alone, before you change anything.**



Before you change anything, get away from everything for half a day. Pick a place outside where nobody needs you: a trail, a river, a bench with a long view. Leave the phone in the truck. Bring a notebook, a pen, water, and something to eat.

Outward Bound courses have a tradition called the solo: a stretch of time alone in the backcountry, from a few hours to a few days, with no phone and nobody asking anything of you. Students rest, write and watch, and it is often where the real thinking happens. Most men have not been truly alone with their own thoughts in years.

How the half day goes

01 **The first hour**
Walk or sit and let your head run. It will be loud at first, with the jobs, the bills and the messages you are missing. That is normal and it settles.

02 **The second hour**
Answer the three questions. Write until you have said the true thing.

03 **The last hour**
Write one page to yourself about what you want the next ninety days to look like, then sit with it.

Smallest version

Two hours, a parking lot with a view, phone in the glovebox, the same three questions. If you cannot get away at all, that is your first answer.

What to bring

A notebook you will keep for the whole course, Two pens, Water and food, A layer for the weather, A watch, if you want to keep time. The phone stays locked in the truck. If you need to be reachable for a real emergency, tell one person where you will be and when you will be back.

After

Read the page once more that night. Tell one person one thing you wrote, if you are willing. Then start Lesson 1 within the week while the Solo is still fresh.

Words to use

“I am taking Saturday morning to get my head straight. I will be back by 1, and I will be better company when I get home.”

FROM CHRIS

After Clemson I led twenty and thirty day canoe trips for Outward Bound, and I watched people change when they finally had quiet and something real in front of them. Most grown men never give themselves that. Give yourself one morning.

THE SOLO · YOUR PAGES

Three questions.

Spend the first hour just walking or sitting. Do not try to fix anything. When your head quiets down, answer three questions on paper. Write until you have said the true thing, even if it is one sentence. Bring the notebook to Lesson 1.

WHAT AM I TIRED OF PRETENDING IS FINE?

WHO GETS THE BEST OF ME RIGHT NOW, AND WHO GETS WHAT IS LEFT?

IF NOTHING CHANGES, WHAT DOES MY LIFE LOOK LIKE IN FIVE YEARS?

THE SOLO · THE LAST HOUR

The next ninety days.

One page to yourself about what you want the next ninety days to look like. Home, work, your body, the people who count on you. Plain words.

PART 01

See it.

Be honest about where you are: your life, your evenings, your temper.



SEE IT · LESSON 1 OF 9

The Honest Map

“I don't know what I want anymore.”

> **See how your life actually stands before you try to fix it.**



The moment

It is Sunday night. The kids are down, the dishwasher is running, and you are staring at the TV without watching it. Nothing is wrong exactly. The business is fine, the house is fine, the family is fine. But there is a restlessness you cannot name, and the week ahead looks exactly like the last fifty.

What is really going on

You built the life you said you wanted, then got too busy running it to ask whether it still fits. When everything feels a little off, nothing gets fixed, because there is no single thing to fix. The fog stays fog until you break it into pieces small enough to look at.

The principle

> **You cannot steer by a feeling. Put an honest number on each part of your life, and the next move usually becomes obvious.**

The practice: A seven area honest map

Use the notebook from your Solo. This takes about thirty minutes, and it only works if you score yourself the way you would if nobody would ever see the page.

01 **Score seven areas**
Give each a number from 1 to 10: work, money, body, marriage or closest relationship, kids, faith or meaning, and friends. Do it fast. Your first number is usually the true one.

02 **Write the why**
Next to each score, write one sentence on why it is that number and not one higher. Specific beats fair: "I have not had a real conversation with my daughter in a month" beats "could be better."

03 **Circle the one you avoid**
There is one area you did not want to score. You already know which one it is. Circle it, even if it is not the lowest.

04 **Make one move**
Write one action on the circled area for the next seven days, with a day and a time. Make it small enough that you will actually do it.

If this week is hard

Score the seven areas in your head on the drive home. Pick the lowest one and do one thing about it before Friday. You can do the full page next week.

At home

Tell your wife, or the person closest to you, which area you circled and what your move is. You do not need to explain the whole map. Saying the move out loud to someone who will notice makes you more likely to do it.

At work

Run the same scoring on your business or your role: revenue, your people, your own time, and whether you still like it. The area you avoid at work is often the one quietly pulling down the scores at home.

If this does not fit your life

If you are single or divorced, score the closest relationship you have, whether that is with your kids, a brother or a friend. If you do not have kids, score the people you are responsible for, like a team or a younger man you look out for.

Why it helps

Vague dissatisfaction is hard to act on. Breaking it into areas turns one heavy feeling into a few concrete problems, and a small plan with a set time and place makes it more likely you will follow through.

Research: Implementation intentions. Links are on the lesson page.

Words to use

"I scored my life this weekend. The one I have been avoiding is ____. This week I am going to ____."

Watch for

Treat the page as a map of where to start. A low number tells you where the work is, and nothing more. Do not try to fix all seven at once. One move on one area is the whole assignment.

YOUR SHEET · LESSON 1

The Honest Map · The seven areas, a line for each why, and a box for this week's move. Lives at: The notebook from your Solo.

This week

Fill out the map, make your one move, and come back to the page next Sunday to see whether the circled number moved.

FROM CHRIS

Every man I know rounds at least one number up. The one you rounded is usually the one worth your attention first.

NOTES

LESSON 1 · YOUR PAGES

What actually happened.

Write what happened, not what should have. Nobody is grading this.

REFLECT: WHICH NUMBER DID I ROUND UP, AND WHY?

THE QUESTION I WOULD ASK YOU ON A CALL: WHICH NUMBER DID YOU ROUND UP, AND WHAT WOULD IT TAKE TO MOVE IT BY ONE?

WHAT I TRIED THIS WEEK, AT HOME AND AT WORK

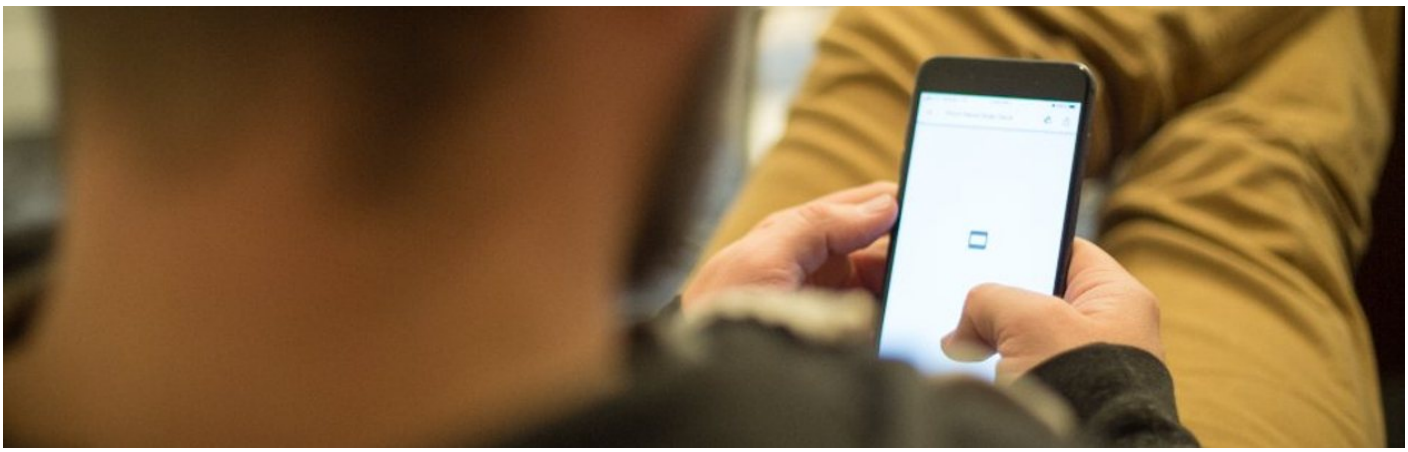
WHAT I AM CARRYING INTO NEXT WEEK

SEE IT · LESSON 2 OF 9

The Drift

“I'm on my phone or a drink every night and I don't like it.”

> **Find out what you reach for at night, and what you are reaching away from.**



The moment

The kids are down by 8:30. You sit down “for a minute” with the phone and a beer. At 10:45 you look up, three beers in, thumb still moving, and you could not tell anyone a single thing you read. You go to bed tired and a little disgusted with yourself, and tomorrow night looks the same.

What is really going on

By evening you are spent, and the easiest thing in reach is whatever turns the volume down. I lived a version of this for about twelve years: in the house but not really there, usually behind a screen. The drift comes from the same small reach every night until it becomes the shape of your evening, and the people in the next room learn to stop asking for you.

The principle

> **You cannot quit a reach you do not understand. Notice what you are feeling right before you reach, then set up something better before you need it.**

The practice: The 9 PM plan

One week of noticing, then one change you set up in advance.

01 **Keep a reach log for seven nights**
Each night, write what you reached for, roughly how long, and what you felt right before, whether tired, bored, angry, lonely or wired. Change nothing yet.

02 **Find the pattern**
At the end of the week, circle the feeling that shows up most. That feeling is the real problem, and the phone or the drink is your fix for it.

03 **Build the replacement**
Pick one thing that answers that feeling better. Tired calls for an earlier bedtime. Lonely calls for a call to a friend or time with your wife. Wired calls for a walk, the garage or a book. Set it up before dinner so it is waiting for you.

04 **Move the fix out of reach**
The phone charges in the kitchen at 9. The beer waits until Friday. Make the drift take more effort than the plan.

If this week is hard

Do only one thing: the phone sleeps outside your bedroom every night this week.

At home

Tell your wife, or whoever you live with, what you are trying, and ask them to point it out with a look instead of a speech when they see you drift. Then spend the first twenty minutes you win back with them.

At work

The same reach happens at 2 PM between meetings, when a hard task gets uncomfortable. Notice when you open the phone with no reason. It is the same muscle, and catching it at work makes it easier to catch at night.

If this does not fit your life

If you live alone, the drift costs you sleep, friends and the things you used to make with your hands. Point the plan at one of those.

Why it helps

Research suggests that even having your own phone within reach can draw down your attention when you are not using it. Naming the feeling behind the reach gives you a better fix to choose, and moving the phone or the drink out of easy reach makes the old habit take effort.

Research: Brain Drain (Ward and colleagues, 2017); Rethinking Drinking (NIAAA). Links are on the lesson page.

Words to use

“I have been disappearing into my phone at night. I am putting it in the kitchen at 9 this week. If you see me drift, just give me a look.”

Watch for

Do not swap one numbing habit for another, like trading the phone for more TV. Do not make this a public crusade at home. Change quietly and let the people around you notice.

A STRAIGHT WORD

If you have tried to cut back on drinking and could not, or you drink to get through the day, that is bigger than a habit and it deserves real help from a doctor or counselor. Coaching is the wrong tool for that, and I will tell you so.

YOUR SHEET · LESSON 2

The Reach Log · A seven night tracker with the feeling column and your 9 PM plan. Lives at: The kitchen counter, next to where the phone charges.

This week

Keep the reach log for seven nights. On night eight, set up your replacement and move the fix out of reach.

FROM CHRIS

I lost about twelve years to the drift, a few minutes at a time. None of those nights felt like a big deal on its own. Added up, they were.

NOTES

LESSON 2 · YOUR PAGES

What actually happened.

Write what happened, not what should have. Nobody is grading this.

REFLECT: WHAT AM I TRYING NOT TO FEEL AT 9 PM?

THE QUESTION I WOULD ASK YOU ON A CALL: WHAT ARE YOU TRYING NOT TO FEEL AT 9 PM, AND WHAT WOULD ACTUALLY HELP WITH IT?

WHAT I TRIED THIS WEEK, AT HOME AND AT WORK

WHAT I AM CARRYING INTO NEXT WEEK

SEE IT · LESSON 3 OF 9

Short Fuse

"I snap at the people I love most."

> **Catch the anger in your body before it reaches your mouth.**



The moment

You held it together all day: the client who moved the goalposts, the crew that showed up late, the bank that called twice. You were patient with every one of them. Then you walk in the door, trip over your son's cleats in the hall, and go off. He freezes. Your wife gives you the look. Ten minutes later you feel terrible, and you do not say so.

What is really going on

The anger at home usually starts somewhere else. You absorb pressure all day that you cannot show at work, and it comes out where it feels safe, which is on the people who love you most. The cleats were only the last straw. The fix starts earlier, in your body, before the words come out.

The principle

> **You get about a second between the surge and the words. Learn to feel it coming, use that second, and when you miss, go back and repair it.**

The practice: Catch, reset, return, repair

Four moves you can use in any room. The last one matters most.

01 **Catch**
Learn your three warning signs. For most men it is some mix of a tight jaw, a hot face, a clipped voice, a clenched fist, or a quiet that everyone in the house knows. Write yours down.

02 **Reset**
When you feel one, take sixty seconds. Stand up, step outside or into another room, and take three slow breaths with the breath out longer than the breath in.

03 **Return**
Come back within the time you said and start with one calm sentence. If you need longer, say so and name when you will come back.

04 **Repair**
When you miss, and you will, go back within the hour. Say what you did, say you were wrong, and stop there with no excuse attached. Kids learn more from a father who repairs than from one who never slips.

If this week is hard

One reset a day, at the moment you walk in the door from work.

At home

Tell the people you live with that you are working on this and what your reset looks like. Then when you step out of the room, they know you are trying instead of leaving.

At work

Use the same reset before you answer the email that made you angry or walk into the hard meeting. The whole room feels how you walk in, and so does your crew.

If this does not fit your life

If you live alone, the fuse usually shows up on the road, on the phone with your ex, or with the people who work for you. Same practice, different room.

Why it helps

Emotion regulation research suggests that small, flexible strategies used early work better than trying to hold it in once you are already hot. Slow breathing with a longer breath out has been linked with signs of a calmer nervous system, though that research is still early.

Research: Emotion regulation overview; Slow breathing review (Zaccaro and colleagues, 2018). Links are on the lesson page.

Words to use

“I am too wound up to answer well. Give me ten minutes. I will come back.”
“I snapped at you. That was wrong. I am sorry.”

Watch for

A pause without a return time can feel like punishment to the people waiting. Always say when you will be back, and come back. A repair that ends with “but you” is no repair at all.

A STRAIGHT WORD

If your anger has ever scared the people you live with, or turned physical, get help from a licensed counselor now. That is beyond what coaching does, and it is the strongest thing you can do for your family.

YOUR SHEET · LESSON 3

The Short Fuse Card · Your three warning signs, the sixty second reset, and your pause and repair sentences. Lives at: Your wallet.

This week

Write your three warning signs and your two sentences. Use the reset at least once a day and the repair every time you need it.

FROM CHRIS

The repair is the part most of us skip. I would rather my kids watch me get it wrong and come back than never see me come back at all.

NOTES

LESSON 3 · YOUR PAGES

What actually happened.

Write what happened, not what should have. Nobody is grading this.

REFLECT: WHAT WAS I CARRYING IN THE HOUR BEFORE I SNAPPED?

THE QUESTION I WOULD ASK YOU ON A CALL: WHAT WERE YOU CARRYING IN THE HOUR BEFORE YOU SNAPPED, AND WHERE DID YOU PICK IT UP?

WHAT I TRIED THIS WEEK, AT HOME AND AT WORK

WHAT I AM CARRYING INTO NEXT WEEK

PART 02

Carry it.

Handle the load: what is yours, how much is enough, and the body that carries it.



CARRY IT · LESSON 4 OF 9

Choose Your Battles

"Everything is on me."

> **Decide which fights are yours, which ones you hand off, and which ones you drop.**



The moment

Payroll is Friday and a big client is thirty days late. The roof needs work before winter. Your mom has a doctor's appointment you said you would drive her to. Your daughter is struggling in math and nobody has called the teacher. You are lying awake running all of it, and your wife has no idea how much of it is sitting on your chest.

What is really going on

Some of what you carry is yours. Some of it you picked up because nobody else did, and some of it you kept because carrying it felt easier than having the conversation. Every man in an epic story has to decide which battles are his, which he walks away from, and which ones he asks for help with. Carrying everything feels like strength, and over time it makes you slower and angrier than the man people need.

The principle

> **A leader chooses his battles on purpose. Carry what is yours, hand off what belongs to someone else, and put down what was never yours.**

The practice: Three columns and one conversation

About thirty minutes with a pen, then one conversation this week.

01 **Unload it**
Write down everything you are carrying right now: work, money, house, family, health, people. Keep going until the page feels honest.

02 **Sort it**
Put each item in one of three columns: Mine to fight, Mine to hand off, and Not mine at all.

03 **Move it**
For each hand off, write who takes it and when you will ask. For each item that is not yours, decide what you will say, or simply stop picking it up.

04 **Have one hard conversation**
Pick the conversation you have been avoiding the longest. Decide when and where you will have it this week. Say the true thing in as few words as you can, then stop talking and listen.

If this week is hard

Move one item out of the first column. That is enough.

At home

Tell your wife, or the person closest to you, one thing you have been carrying alone. You do not need a solution, only to say it out loud. Ask what she is carrying alone too.

At work

Hand off one thing you have been doing because "it is faster if I do it myself." Accept that it will be done a little worse for a while. That is the price of a team that can carry weight without you.

If this does not fit your life

If you do not have a partner or a team, look at who could share the load: a brother, a friend, a hired hand, a bookkeeper. Paying for help can be the cheapest thing you buy all year.

Why it helps

Sorting a heavy load into what you own and what you do not turns one crushing feeling into decisions you can actually make. Deciding exactly when and where you will have a hard conversation makes it more likely you will have it.

Research: Implementation intentions. Links are on the lesson page.

Words to use

"I have been carrying ____ on my own and I need help with it."
"This is yours now. Here is what good looks like. Come to me if you get stuck."

Watch for

Handing off is different from dumping. Give people what they need to succeed. Do not use "not mine" as a way to dodge something that really is your responsibility.

YOUR SHEET · LESSON 4

Three Columns · Mine to fight, Mine to hand off, Not mine at all, and a line for this week's hard conversation. Lives at: Your desk.

This week

Fill the three columns, make two hand offs, and have the one conversation.

FROM CHRIS

Picking everything up feels like leadership. Putting something down on purpose is a decision too, and it is usually the harder and better one.

NOTES

LESSON 4 · YOUR PAGES

What actually happened.

Write what happened, not what should have. Nobody is grading this.

REFLECT: WHAT AM I CARRYING BECAUSE IT IS MINE, AND WHAT AM I CARRYING BECAUSE I AM AFRAID OF THE CONVERSATION?

THE QUESTION I WOULD ASK YOU ON A CALL: WHAT ARE YOU CARRYING BECAUSE IT IS YOURS, AND WHAT ARE YOU CARRYING BECAUSE YOU ARE AFRAID OF THE CONVERSATION?

WHAT I TRIED THIS WEEK, AT HOME AND AT WORK

WHAT I AM CARRYING INTO NEXT WEEK

CARRY IT · LESSON 5 OF 9

Enough

“Work owns me.”

> **Define enough money, enough hours and enough yes, so the business stops setting the terms.**



The moment

You are on the sideline at your daughter's game and your phone buzzes. A client needs “one quick thing.” You step away to handle it, and when you look up the game is over and she is walking toward you asking if you saw her goal. You did not. Sunday night already feels like Monday morning, and you cannot remember the last full day you did not check email.

What is really going on

You started the business, or took the job, to give your family a good life. Somewhere along the way it started running you. Work expands to fill whatever room you give it, and a man who never defines enough will never reach it. Most men know they should work less. Very few have written down the numbers that would let them.

The principle

> **Enough is a number you choose. Write it down, set one hard edge, and protect it like a client.**

The practice: Three numbers and one edge

Write the numbers once, then keep one edge every day for thirty days.

01 **Enough money**
Write what your household actually needs each month, plus what you want to save, and nothing else. Compare it to what you made last year.

02 **Enough hours**
Write the most you will work in a normal week, counting the evenings and weekends you pretend do not count. Then track this week's real hours against it.

03 **Enough yes**
Write how many new commitments you will take on this month, and one thing you will turn down to protect them.

04 **One hard edge for thirty days**
Pick one: no work after 7 PM, no phone at dinner, or Saturday mornings belong to the family. Tell your clients or your team what the new edge is, so you are not keeping it secretly.

If this week is hard

One evening this week with the phone in another room from dinner to bedtime.

At home

Tell your family the edge you picked and let them hold you to it. Kids are excellent enforcers, and they will remember that you kept it.

At work

Look at last month and find the one client, project or habit that cost the most time for the least return. Decide this week whether to raise the price, change the terms or let it go.

If this does not fit your life

If you work for someone else, you may not control your hours, but you usually control the edges: when you check email, whether the phone comes to dinner, and how many extra projects you volunteer for.

Why it helps

Research on detachment from work links being able to mentally switch off after hours with less exhaustion and better recovery. A written number gives you something to measure against, and a clear edge makes switching off a decision you make once instead of every night.

Research: Detachment from work (meta analysis). Links are on the lesson page.

Words to use

“I am off after 7. I will get to this first thing tomorrow.”
“From dinner to bedtime the phone stays in the kitchen. Call me on it if I slip.”

Watch for

Real emergencies happen. An edge with an honest exception for true emergencies will last longer than a perfect rule you break by Wednesday. Do not let “emergency” quietly come to mean everything.

YOUR SHEET · LESSON 5

Enough · Your three numbers, your hard edge, and thirty boxes to tick each day you keep it. Lives at: The fridge.

This week

Write the three numbers, pick your edge, tell the people it affects, and keep it every day.

FROM CHRIS

I have run a business for twenty years, and the work never runs out on its own. The edge has to come from me, because the clients will never draw it for me.

NOTES

LESSON 5 · YOUR PAGES

What actually happened.

Write what happened, not what should have. Nobody is grading this.

REFLECT: WHAT NUMBER WOULD I HAVE TO SEE BEFORE I BELIEVED I COULD SLOW DOWN?

THE QUESTION I WOULD ASK YOU ON A CALL: WHAT NUMBER WOULD YOU HAVE TO SEE BEFORE YOU BELIEVED YOU COULD SLOW DOWN, AND IS IT REAL OR IS IT FEAR?

WHAT I TRIED THIS WEEK, AT HOME AND AT WORK

WHAT I AM CARRYING INTO NEXT WEEK

CARRY IT · LESSON 6 OF 9

Fuel

“I'm running on fumes.”

> **Sleep, train, get quiet and do one hard thing on purpose, because steadiness gets built in the body first.**



The moment

The alarm goes off at 5:40 after six hours of bad sleep. Your back is stiff, your coffee is your breakfast, and by 3 PM you are fading. You tell yourself you will get back in shape when work slows down. It has not slowed down in years, and the last time you did something physically hard on purpose, your kids were in diapers.

What is really going on

When your body is empty, patience is the first thing to go, and the people at home feel it before you do. A man who sleeps, moves and does hard things on purpose has more room for pressure, because his body has practiced handling strain on his own terms. When I need to reset, I lift kettlebells, ride a mountain bike trail or go fishing.

The principle

> **Fuel the man before you ask more of him. Sleep, movement and voluntary challenge are part of the job.**

The practice: Sleep, train, get quiet, one hard thing

Six parts. Start with the one you are worst at. Sleep, training and the quiet minutes matter most; heat is a bonus if you have it.

01 **Sleep**
Pick a lights out time that gives you seven hours, and keep it five nights this week. Phone out of the bedroom.

02 **Train**
Thirty minutes that raise your heart rate, five days this week, plus two days of strength work. Pushups, a kettlebell in the garage and a pullup bar are enough. A simple week: strength on Monday and Thursday, a hard walk, ride or run on three other days.

03 **Get outside**
At least one of those sessions on a trail, a river or anywhere green, without the phone.

04 **Ten quiet minutes**
Sit for ten minutes a day with nothing in your hands, before anyone else is up or in the truck before you walk in. Notice your breath, notice when your mind runs off, and come back. If you want a guide, the Introductory Course in the Waking Up app gives you a short lesson every day for a month.

05 **Heat, if you have it**
If your gym or a friend has a sauna, use it two or three times a week after training. Start with ten to fifteen minutes, drink water before and after, and leave the phone outside the door. No sauna, no problem; skip this one.

06 **Schedule one hard thing**
Put one voluntary challenge on the calendar in the next month: a long ride, a summit you have never climbed, a race you have to train for. Tell someone, so backing out costs you something.

If this week is hard

Lights out on time three nights, one walk outside without the phone, and five quiet minutes on two mornings.

At home

Bring a kid along for the hard thing, or for the training. They will remember the morning you climbed something together longer than anything you buy them.

At work

Take one phone call a day walking instead of sitting. Block your training time on the calendar the same way you would block a client.

If this does not fit your life

If injury or health limits what you can do, the principle still holds. Pick the hardest thing your doctor says is safe and do it on purpose.

Why it helps

Sleep scientists recommend that adults get at least seven hours a night, and federal guidelines call for 150 to 300 minutes of moderate activity a week plus strength work twice a week. One study found that a ninety minute walk in nature reduced rumination, the loop of replaying what went wrong, while a city walk did not. A review of 47 trials found moderate evidence that mindfulness meditation programs ease anxiety, depression and pain. And in a study that followed 2,315 Finnish men for about twenty years, the men who used a sauna four to seven times a week had about half the risk of dying from cardiovascular disease of men who went once a week. That is an association, not proof, but it is a good reason to sit in the heat.

Research: Sleep recommendation (CDC); Physical Activity Guidelines (Harvard T.H. Chan School of Public Health); Nature walks and rumination (Bratman and colleagues, 2015); Meditation programs (Goyal and colleagues, JAMA Internal Medicine, 2014); Sauna use in Finnish men (Laukkanen and colleagues, JAMA Internal Medicine, 2015). Links are on the lesson page.

Words to use

"I am going to bed at 10:30 this week. Hold me to it."
"I signed up for ____ in March. Want to train for it with me?"
"I am taking ten minutes before anyone else is up. Give me that, and you get a better version of me at breakfast."

Watch for

Do not let this turn into another thing to be perfect at. Missing a day is part of it. And do not train so hard you have nothing left for the people at home. Heat and hard training stack: drink water, skip the sauna after a drink, and get out the moment you feel lightheaded.

A STRAIGHT WORD

If you have health problems, heart trouble in particular, or have not exercised in a long time, check with your doctor before starting anything hard or using a sauna.

YOUR SHEET · LESSON 6

The Fuel Card · Your lights out time, a weekly grid for sleep, training, quiet minutes and heat, and the date of your hard thing. Lives at: The bathroom mirror.

This week

Set the lights out time, get five movement sessions and two strength sessions in, sit for ten quiet minutes a day, and put one hard thing on the calendar.

FROM CHRIS

The kettlebell, the trail and the river are how I reset. When I let them slide for too long, patience is the first thing to go.

NOTES

LESSON 6 · YOUR PAGES

What actually happened.

Write what happened, not what should have. Nobody is grading this.

REFLECT: WHEN DID I LAST DO SOMETHING HARD THAT NOBODY MADE ME DO?

THE QUESTION I WOULD ASK YOU ON A CALL: WHEN DID YOU LAST DO SOMETHING HARD THAT NOBODY MADE YOU DO, AND WHAT DID IT GIVE YOU?

WHAT I TRIED THIS WEEK, AT HOME AND AT WORK

WHAT I AM CARRYING INTO NEXT WEEK

PART 03

Build it.

Build what lasts after you: your friends, what you inherited, and what you pass on.



BUILD IT · LESSON 7 OF 9

Your Council

“I don't have one friend I could call at 2 AM.”

> **Two or three men who know the real story and will tell you the truth.**



The moment

You run into an old buddy at the hardware store. You both say “we need to get together,” mean it, and know it will not happen. Driving home you try to name one man you could call tonight if your marriage cracked or the business went under. You think for a long time.

What is really going on

You know a lot of guys: clients, neighbors, dads from practice, men at church. Very few of them know what is actually going on with you. Men rarely lose friends on purpose. Work and kids fill the calendar, nobody makes the first call, and the friendships quietly fade. If you are married, your wife may have become your only close relationship, and that is a lot to ask of one person.

The principle

> **Every man needs a council: a few men who know the real story and are allowed to tell him the truth. You build one by showing up, side by side, again and again.**

The practice: Name, invite, repeat, tell

A few minutes this week, then a standing habit.

01 **Name them**
Write down every man you respect. Circle two or three who would tell you the truth and who you would trust with yours.

02 **Invite one, specifically**
Text one of them this week with a day, a time and an easy out: "I'm riding Saturday at 7, want to come? No worries if not." Men bond best side by side, so pick something you do together: a ride, a fishing morning, breakfast before work, a project in his garage.

03 **Repeat it**
Put the same thing on the calendar again for next month. Friendship gets built through repetition.

04 **Tell one true thing**
Somewhere around the third time, say one honest sentence about what is going on with you. Then ask him the same.

If this week is hard

One text to one man, with a day and a time in it.

At home

Protect your wife's friendships the same way you protect your own. Trade off mornings so both of you get time with your people. Friends make you a better husband, and hers make her a happier wife.

At work

Find one peer outside your company who runs a business or carries a role like yours, and have lunch once a month to trade notes honestly. Business owners are often the loneliest men in the room.

If this does not fit your life

If you have moved and know nobody, start where men already gather around something: a men's group at church, a running or cycling club, a volunteer crew, a Rotary breakfast. Go three times before deciding.

Why it helps

A large meta analysis found strong associations between social relationships and survival, comparable to other well known health risks. That research does not prove that one breakfast changes your health, but it is a strong reason to take friendship as seriously as your blood pressure.

Research: Social relationships and mortality risk (Holt Lunstad and colleagues, 2010). Links are on the lesson page.

Words to use

"I'm riding Saturday at 7, want to come? No worries if not."
"Honestly, things have been rough at home and I have not told anyone. How are you really doing?"

Watch for

Do not wait until you need someone to start. The council has to exist before the 2 AM call. And do not judge a friendship by the first outing. Men warm up slowly.

YOUR SHEET · LESSON 7

The Council Card · The names of your two or three men, the invitation script, and a line for the next date. Lives at: Your wallet.

This week

Name your two or three, send one invitation, and put the second one on the calendar before the first one happens.

FROM CHRIS

I do not need a big network. I need a few men I can call, and that starts with me being willing to ask first.

NOTES

LESSON 7 · YOUR PAGES

What actually happened.

Write what happened, not what should have. Nobody is grading this.

REFLECT: WHO KNOWS WHAT IS ACTUALLY GOING ON WITH ME RIGHT NOW?

THE QUESTION I WOULD ASK YOU ON A CALL: WHO KNOWS WHAT IS ACTUALLY GOING ON WITH YOU RIGHT NOW, AND IF THE ANSWER IS NOBODY, WHO SHOULD?

WHAT I TRIED THIS WEEK, AT HOME AND AT WORK

WHAT I AM CARRYING INTO NEXT WEEK

BUILD IT · LESSON 8 OF 9

The Inheritance

"I'm turning into my dad."

> **Choose on purpose what you keep from your father and what stops with you.**



The moment

Your son spills milk across the table and before you can think, your father's voice comes out of your mouth: the same words, the same tone, the same sigh. You see your son's face do exactly what yours used to do. Later that night you sit in the truck in the driveway thinking, when did I become him?

What is really going on

Every man runs on a playbook he picked up from his father, from the man who raised him, or from the hole where one should have been. Most of it runs without your noticing: how you handle money, anger, work, love, and asking for help. Some of it is the best of you. Some of it you would rather your kids never learn. You do not need to judge your father to look at it honestly. The point is to choose.

The principle

> **What you inherited is a starting point. Keep the good on purpose, change what needs changing, and let the rest stop with you.**

The practice: Keep, change, stop

One page, written honestly, then one new version practiced out loud.

01 **Write the playbook**
On the left side of a page, write what your father taught you about being a man, in his own words if you can remember them. Cover work, money, anger, love, asking for help, and how a man treats his wife and kids.

02 **Mark each line**
Next to each one write Keep, Change or Stop.

03 **Write the new version**
For each Change or Stop, write the version you want your kids to inherit, in one sentence.

04 **Practice one**
Pick the line that matters most to your kids right now and practice the new version this week, out loud, at least once.

If this week is hard

One line on the page, marked Keep, Change or Stop, with the new version written out.

At home

Tell one of your kids something good your father taught you. They should know where the good parts came from, and it gives you a way to talk about family without making it heavy.

At work

A lot of fathers taught their sons how to run a crew or a company, for better or worse. Find one leadership habit that came straight from him and decide if it still serves the people you lead.

If this does not fit your life

If your father was absent, write what his absence taught you, and who filled in, whether a grandfather, a coach or nobody. If you do not have kids, the people you lead and mentor inherit your playbook too.

Why it helps

A 2025 review of 24 datasets found that parenting carries over from one generation to the next only weakly. In plain words, you are far from destined to repeat your father. Writing the playbook down drags the automatic parts into the light where you can choose.

Research: Intergenerational stability in parenting (Psychological Bulletin, 2025). Links are on the lesson page.

Words to use

“My dad taught me ____. I want you to have that too.”
“That one stops with me.”

Watch for

This lesson is about what you do from here forward, so leave settling scores and digging through every old hurt for another place. And remember he probably inherited his playbook too.

A STRAIGHT WORD

For some men this lesson brings up hard things from childhood. If it does, a licensed counselor is the right person to walk through that with you. Coaching works on what you do from here forward.

YOUR SHEET · LESSON 8

Keep, Change, Stop · The playbook column, the three marks, and the new versions. Lives at: The back of your Solo notebook.

This week

Write the playbook, mark every line, and practice one new version out loud at least once.

FROM CHRIS

None of us picked the playbook we started with. We do get to pick what we hand on, and that choice gets made in small moments like the milk on the table.

NOTES

LESSON 8 · YOUR PAGES

What actually happened.

Write what happened, not what should have. Nobody is grading this.

REFLECT: WHAT IS ONE THING MY FATHER DID THAT I AM STILL DOING, AND DO I WANT MY KIDS TO DO IT TOO?

THE QUESTION I WOULD ASK YOU ON A CALL: WHAT IS ONE THING YOUR FATHER DID THAT YOU ARE STILL DOING, AND DO YOU WANT YOUR SON OR DAUGHTER TO DO IT TOO?

WHAT I TRIED THIS WEEK, AT HOME AND AT WORK

WHAT I AM CARRYING INTO NEXT WEEK

BUILD IT · LESSON 9 OF 9

What You Pass On

"My kids are growing up and I'm missing it."

> **Decide what you are building, take your kids into real challenges, and put it on one page.**



The moment

You are looking for something in the garage and find your son's first bike, the one with training wheels. He is fourteen now and taller than his mother. You try to remember the last real conversation you had with him that was not about grades or chores, and you cannot. You do the math on how many summers are left before he leaves.

What is really going on

You have been providing for your kids, and that matters. But kids also need a father who takes them into the world: who teaches them to do hard things, lets them see how he handles a problem, and tells them who they are. You will not get those years back, and the good news is that a few deliberate moments and a clear idea of what you want to pass on are enough to start.

The principle

> **Your kids inherit how you live far more than what you say. Decide what you want to pass on, then take them into it.**

The practice: The creed and the challenge

One page to write, then a month of doing something hard together.

01 **Write your creed**
One page, in plain words: who you are, what you are building, how you treat people, and how you want your kids to remember you. Read it once a week, Sunday night.

02 **Plan one challenge with each kid**
Something a little hard that you do together over a month: a summit, a fishing trip they plan, a project in the shop, learning to change a tire, a race. Let them carry part of the load.

03 **Teach one real skill**
Pick something you know that they will need, like how to shake a hand and look a man in the eye, how to handle money, how to fix something, how to apologize. Teach it this month.

04 **Tell them who they are**
Once this week, tell each kid one specific thing you see in them that you are proud of. Say it plainly and do not attach advice to it.

If this week is hard

One drive or one walk with one kid, phone in your pocket on silent, and one question about their life that is not about school.

At home

Share your creed with your wife or co parent and ask what she would add. The kids get one family, and the two of you passing on the same things counts for a lot.

At work

The younger men on your crew or team are watching you too. Pick one and teach him something real this month: how you price a job, how you handle an angry client, how you run a meeting.

If this does not fit your life

If you do not have kids, or they are grown, aim this at a nephew, a younger man at work, a kid on a team you coach, or your grown kids, who still need to hear who they are.

Why it helps

A review of research on play between fathers and children found a varied but meaningful body of evidence connecting it with child outcomes. A study of family mealtimes linked adult phone use with less talking at the table. Small, focused moments are where kids actually get their father.

Research: Father and child play (systematic review); Phones during family routines. Links are on the lesson page.

Words to use

“I want to do something hard with you this fall. You pick it.”
“I noticed how you handled ____. That took guts. I am proud of you.”

Watch for

Do not make the challenge your dream instead of theirs. Let them pick, let them struggle a little, and resist the urge to take over. And do not save the proud words for big achievements. They need to hear them on ordinary days.

YOUR SHEET · LESSON 9

My Creed · Space for your creed, your challenge with each kid, and the skill you are teaching this month. Lives at: Somewhere you will see it on Sunday nights.

This week

Write a first draft of your creed, plan one challenge with each kid, and tell each one what you see in them.

FROM CHRIS

I have three kids. The creed keeps me honest about what I am actually handing them, especially on the weeks when work wants all of me.

NOTES

LESSON 9 · YOUR PAGES

What actually happened.

Write what happened, not what should have. Nobody is grading this.

REFLECT: WHAT DO I WANT MY KIDS TO SAY ABOUT ME WHEN I AM GONE?

THE QUESTION I WOULD ASK YOU ON A CALL: WHAT DO YOU WANT YOUR KIDS TO SAY ABOUT YOU WHEN YOU ARE GONE, AND WHAT DID YOU DO THIS WEEK THAT THEY WOULD PUT IN THAT SENTENCE?

WHAT I TRIED THIS WEEK, AT HOME AND AT WORK

WHAT I AM CARRYING INTO NEXT WEEK

AFTER THE NINE · THE LAST PAGE

Keep the two that helped.

Do not keep every practice because you paid for the course. Choose two that meet a problem you actually have, and give each a moment, a response, and a smallest version for a bad week. Make at least one of them show up at work.

Two practices you keep beat nine you admired.

THE TWO PRACTICES I AM KEEPING

THE MOMENT EACH ONE IS FOR, AT HOME AND AT WORK

THE SMALLEST VERSION I WILL STILL DO ON A BAD WEEK

WHO WILL ASK ME ABOUT THIS AT DAY FIFTEEN

WHAT I WANT TO LOOK AT AGAIN IN THIRTY DAYS

A TOOL FOR LESSON 2 · THE FOCUS PROTOCOL

If the phone is your reach.

Four moves for seventy two hours. A short experiment in changing your surroundings: cut down what pulls at you, add enough friction to notice the reflex, and make a different choice. Willpower has very little to do with it.

01 Remove the color

Make the phone less visually demanding.

Switch the display to grayscale for the 72 hour experiment. Removing the color puts a small speed bump between the impulse and the tap.

Make it fit: Turn color back on when it is genuinely needed for work, maps, photos, health, or accessibility.

02 Control the feeds

Choose which inputs reach you during the reset.

Delete or sign out of the few apps you open without deciding. Keep essential tools. You are noticing the reflex. Nobody is asking you to live without a smartphone.

Make it fit: Use a browser or scheduled desktop window if an app is required for work or caregiving.

03 Silence the machine

Let people reach you without letting every platform interrupt you.

Turn off nonessential notifications. Keep priority calls, texts, medical alerts, authentication, and anything a caregiver truly needs.

Make it fit: Set navigation before the car moves and keep the phone out of your hand while driving. A notification is never worth a downward glance on the road.

04 Give the phone a home

Protect one repeated moment instead of policing the whole day.

Try a clear arrival rule: when you get home, the phone goes to one drawer, bag, or charging station instead of following you from room to room. If all evening is unrealistic, protect dinner, bedtime, a game, or the first hour after you walk in. Adults model the boundary first.

Make it fit: Allow priority contacts and tell people how to reach you. Shorten or move the window when work, health, accessibility, or caregiving requires it.

THE FOCUS PROTOCOL · WHAT THE 72 HOURS CAN FEEL LIKE

Know the hard part before you reach it.

0 to 6 — **The phantom reach**
Your hand goes to the pocket with no thought behind it. You will catch yourself unlocking a phone you had no reason to unlock. Nothing is wrong. You are simply meeting a habit you have never had to look at directly.

6 to 18 — **The boredom**
This is the hard part and it is the part most people quit in. Small gaps in the day that used to be filled are suddenly empty, and empty feels worse than it should. The urge to check will be strong and it will feel reasonable. It passes.

18 to 36 — **The settle**
The noise drops. Most people notice they are reaching less, that a task holds them longer, and that falling asleep gets easier. You did not fix yourself. There is just less arriving.

36 to 72 — **The room gets bigger**
Conversations run longer. You hear the second half of what someone says instead of the first half. The reflex is still there and it is quieter. This is the part worth keeping.

When the old habit starts negotiating

The seventy two hours end and your head starts negotiating. It sounds reasonable, it sounds like you, and it shows up almost word for word.

“I proved I can handle it.”
“Just one app. Not the bad ones.”
“Ten minutes is not the same thing.”
“It was a crazy week. This was not a fair test.”

> **Every one of those is the habit asking for its old conditions back. Hold the setup for fourteen days before you change anything. If an app comes back and the reaching starts again, run the seventy two hours one more time.**

The declaration

> **I do not trade presence for distraction. My attention belongs to the people who count on me. My phone is a tool. I am not.**